

But then, I don't use coupons to have praises lauded upon me for my super savings. That's just a nice bonus. I started using coupons to save money. I kept using them because it turned out to be a fun and rewarding way to shop. At some point, the fun turned into an obsession. There is a subtle difference between the casual couponer and the serious couponer, but there is a world of difference between a casual user and those "crazy" couponers like me: the ones bordering on the edge of freakdom.

Inmar's Advantage Update "The 2009 Consumer Study" segmented coupon users into six distinct groups based on their semi-annual buying habits in the first half of 2009. The coupon user groups were as follows: nonusers, super low users, those who used 1–3 coupons in a six-month period, those super heavy users who used 51–103 coupons in a six-month period, and the final category, "Coupon Enthusiasts," those who used 104 or more in a six-month period.

To the average reader, this kind of categorization makes sense. But to a "shoptimizer," there seems to be one important category left unrepresented. For an example of the missing category, check out my typical shopping habits in early 2012:

Day 1: Saturday: Check the upcoming week's ads and Sunday's coupon inserts online at www.RefundCents.com, and take note of any good deals I want to take advantage of. (*30 minutes to 1 hour*)

Day 2: Sunday: After putting on a pot of coffee, pick up the newspaper off the front porch and, with pad of paper and pen handy, immediately pull out the coupon inserts and ads. Scrutinize both and match up any super deals for the week. Begin writing